THE WORLD OF 2006

The Country, the Culture, and the Hollywood Machine

STORY BIBLE — VOLUME 14: WORLD-BUILDING

As of **Friday, April 28, 2006**

How to read this volume: everything here is real history **except** the parts of our alternate history: Donohue Entertainment in Disney's place, the fictional actors and families, and the way the MCU gets made. Fictional elements are marked **[OUR WORLD]**.

1. Today at a Glance: Friday, April 28, 2006

Item	Detail
President	George W. Bush, second term. His approval rating is in the mid-30s. Dick Cheney is Vice President.
Fed chair	Ben Bernanke, in the job since February 1, 2006
Dow Jones	Around 11,350
Unemployment	About 4.7%
Gas	Nearly $3 a gallon and climbing
Stamp / minimum wage	39 cents (up since January) / $5.15 an hour (unchanged since 1997)
Average movie ticket	About $6.55
Median home price	About $220,000, at the top of the housing bubble
Opening in theaters today	*United 93* (Universal), *Akeelah and the Bee* (Lionsgate), *RV*, *Stick It*
No. 1 song	Daniel Powter, “Bad Day”. Gnarls Barkley's “Crazy” is everywhere.
On TV	*American Idol* season 5 is in its final weeks (Taylor Hicks wins May 24). *Lost*, *Grey's Anatomy* and *Desperate Housewives* (all ABC, so **[OUR WORLD]** Donohue-owned), plus *House*, *24*, *CSI* and *Deal or No Deal*.
Celebrity news	Tom Cruise and Katie Holmes's daughter Suri was born April 18. Brad Pitt and Angelina Jolie are expecting, with Shiloh due May 27. TMZ (launched November 2005) and Perez Hilton set the pace of gossip.

2. The Country

Politics and War

- **Iraq:** in its fourth year, with nearly 2,400 American service members killed. The war dominates the news and the country is tired of it.
- **Hurricane Katrina** (August 29, 2005): eight months later, New Orleans is still in ruins and the federal response is a national scandal. Kanye West's live-TV line, *"George Bush doesn't care about black people"* (September 2, 2005), is still being argued about. The Essence Music Festival moves to Houston this July because of the storm.
- **Immigration:** on March 25, half a million people marched in Los Angeles. A nationwide "Day Without Immigrants" is set for May 1.
- **Midterm elections** on November 7, 2006 will flip both houses of Congress to the Democrats.
- **Rising name:** Barack Obama, Illinois's freshman senator. His book *The Audacity of Hope* comes out October 17.
- **Supreme Court:** Chief Justice John Roberts (since 2005) and Justice Samuel Alito (since January 31, 2006).

The Economy

Easy credit, house flipping and boom-time confidence. Home prices are peaking, and nobody on TV says "subprime" yet. Hollywood is awash in hedge-fund and Wall Street film financing, the same money that funded Marvel's $525 million Merrill Lynch deal. In two years, the 2008 financial crisis will turn every one of those deals into drama.

Technology and Daily Life

- **Phones:** the Motorola RAZR flip phone and the BlackBerry, which executives check under the table. The iPhone doesn't exist until June 2007.
- **Music:** the video iPod (October 2005) and iTunes. Albums still sell, though file-sharing is gutting the industry.
- **Internet:** MySpace, owned by News Corp since 2005, is the center of online social life. YouTube is a year old (Google buys it in October). Facebook opens to everyone on **September 26**. Twitter launches in **July**. Wikipedia, AOL Instant Messenger and blogs are everywhere.
- **Home video:** Netflix mails DVDs. The HD DVD vs. Blu-ray format war has just started: HD DVD arrived April 18, and Blu-ray follows June 20.
- **Games:** the Xbox 360 (November 2005). The PlayStation 3 and Wii arrive in November 2006.

Culture and Race in 2006

Hip-hop is pop culture: T.I.'s *King* (March 28), crunk, snap music, Mary J. Blige, Chris Brown and Ne-Yo, with Beyoncé's *B'Day* coming in September. Black America is processing Katrina's racial reckoning while a growing Black middle class is visible in suburbs like View Park and Ladera Heights. Tabloid culture is at its most savage: celebutantes, paparazzi wars and Britney Spears.

3. The Hollywood Machine

The Studios: Donohue and “The Other Five”

Studio	Parent company	April 2006 situation
Donohue Entertainment (Buena Vista, Touchstone, Miramax, Pixar)	**[OUR WORLD]** Donohue Entertainment, Inc.	The giant. *Pirates of the Caribbean: Dead Man's Chest* (July 7) will set an opening-weekend record. The Pixar deal closes May 5, with *Cars* on June 9. Sometimes called “the Mouse House,” and feared like no other studio.
Warner Bros.	Time Warner	*Harry Potter* and the DC films. *Superman Returns* opens June 28 and *Happy Feet* on November 17.
Paramount	Viacom (which split from CBS on December 31, 2005)	Brad Grey is in charge, and Paramount has just absorbed DreamWorks' live-action studio. **It distributes Marvel Studios' self-financed films.** *Mission: Impossible III* opens May 5.
20th Century Fox	News Corp	Owns the X-Men, the Fantastic Four and Daredevil film rights. *X-Men: The Last Stand* opens May 26. Tom Rothman runs the film side. *The Simpsons* is on its network.
Universal	NBC Universal (GE)	Distributes *The Incredible Hulk* for Marvel.
Sony / Columbia	Sony (and MGM since 2005)	Spider-Man (*Spider-Man 3*, May 4, 2007) and Ghost Rider. *The Da Vinci Code* opens May 19.

The rising independents: **Lionsgate** (the *Saw* films, Tyler Perry), **The Weinstein Company** (founded October 2005 after Bob and Harvey Weinstein left Miramax, which is Donohue-owned **[OUR WORLD]**), and **New Line** (*The Lord of the Rings*, Blade).

Where the Money Is

- **DVD is king:** home video sales are at their all-time peak, roughly $16 billion a year in the U.S. For many films, DVD earns more than the theatrical run.
- **The 2005 slump:** theater attendance fell, and the press asked whether moviegoing was dying. 2006 is the recovery year, driven by franchises.
- **Franchise fever:** sequels, remakes and comic-book movies. The risk is enormous, and nobody has built a shared universe. *Elektra* (2005) bombed and *Fantastic Four* (2005) was mocked. Comic-book movies are seen as a licensing game, not a strategy.
- **Windows war:** Steven Soderbergh's *Bubble* (January 2006) opened in theaters, on cable and on DVD almost at once, and theater owners are furious.

Power Players

- **Agencies:** CAA, William Morris, Endeavor, UTA and ICM. A phone call from the right agent can decide a casting.
- **Guilds:** the Writers Guild contract expires October 31, 2007, and the WGA will strike from November 5, 2007 to February 12, 2008. That's a future storm for every film in development.
- **The trades:** *Variety* and *The Hollywood Reporter* in print. Nikki Finke's *Deadline Hollywood Daily* (launched March 2006) breaks scoops online and terrifies executives.
- **Fan sites:** Ain't It Cool News, Superhero Hype, Newsarama and Comic Book Resources. One leaked script review can sink a project.

Kids' TV: The Star Factories

Network	2006 status
Donohue Channel [OUR WORLD]	Unstoppable: *High School Musical* (January 20, 2006) is a phenomenon, *Hannah Montana* premiered March 24, and *That's So Raven*, led by Raven-Symoné, is the channel's biggest show. *Kid Mayor* (Marc-Anthony) runs in endless reruns. Natasha's 2005 no-family rule is in force.
Nickelodeon	*SpongeBob*, *Drake & Josh*, *Zoey 101* and *Avatar: The Last Airbender*. *The Wild Life of Danny Price* (Marc-Anthony, 1999-2003) is in reruns **[OUR WORLD]**.

Awards Season 2006 (Just Ended)

At the March 5 Oscars, hosted by Jon Stewart, *Crash* upset *Brokeback Mountain* for Best Picture. Philip Seymour Hoffman (*Capote*) and Reese Witherspoon (*Walk the Line*) won the lead acting prizes. **Terrence Howard**, our Rhodey, was nominated for Best Actor for *Hustle & Flow*, and Three 6 Mafia won Best Original Song for “It's Hard Out Here for a Pimp,” a landmark night for Black Hollywood. The NAACP Image Awards were held February 25.

4. Black Hollywood: Two Thrones

The Real Landscape

Will Smith is the biggest box-office star on Earth (*The Pursuit of Happyness* opens December 15). **Denzel Washington** has a hit with Spike Lee's *Inside Man* (March 24). **Jamie Foxx** has an Oscar for *Ray*, with *Miami Vice* and *Dreamgirls* coming. **Halle Berry** is the only Black woman to have won Best Actress (2002). **Tyler Perry**'s *Madea's Family Reunion* opened at No. 1 in February and proved the Black audience is a powerhouse studios keep underestimating. **Oprah Winfrey** is the most influential person in American media. **BET** (Viacom) airs *106 & Park*, and the BET Awards are June 27.

Our World: The Two Courts [OUR WORLD]

	THE DONOHUE COURT (Bel Air and Burbank)	THE SMILLEY COURT (View Park)
Represents	The empire: ownership, power, the future	Old royalty: pedigree, respectability, the past
Seat of power	The Bel Air estate and the Burbank studio lot	The View Park estate (since 1962)
Awards-season ritual	**Sunday Supper**, Victor and Joan's invitation-only dinner on the Sunday before the Oscars	**Founders' Brunch**, held the same Sunday morning in Zeke's honor
Loyalists	Most of the industry, because Donohue signs the checks	The old guard, church circles and HBCU alumni networks; anyone the Donohues ever crossed
The unwritten rule	Nobody attends both. RSVP lists leak to gossip blogs every year.	Same. Choosing a side is a career decision.

Industry Slang [OUR WORLD]

Term	Meaning
“Getting Donohued”	Being bought out, outmaneuvered or quietly frozen out of the industry. *“His show didn't get canceled. He got Donohued.”*
“Smilley-safe”	Squeaky-clean and family-friendly. Used as praise or as a dig.

Term	Meaning
“Burbank weather”	Whatever Donohue decides this week, which everyone else has to dress for.
“A View Park invitation”	Old-guard respect: being taken seriously as an artist rather than a commodity.
“Put it on my tab”	Royce Goodwell's *Simpsons* catchphrase, now on T-shirts and in rap lyrics.

5. The Superhero Landscape

Year	Marvel-character films (licensed out)	Elsewhere
2000-2004	*X-Men*, *X2* (Fox); *Spider-Man* 1-2 (Sony); *Daredevil* (Fox); *Hulk* (Universal); *The Punisher* (Lionsgate); *Blade II*, *Blade: Trinity* (New Line)	The *Spider-Man* films are the high-water mark.
2005	*Elektra* (a flop), *Fantastic Four* (a hit, but mocked), *Man-Thing*	*Batman Begins* (Warner/DC) shows a grounded, serious tone can work.
2006	*X-Men: The Last Stand* (May 26)	*V for Vendetta* (March 17); *Superman Returns* (June 28)
2007 (coming)	*Ghost Rider* (Feb 16), *Spider-Man 3* (May 4), *Fantastic Four: Rise of the Silver Surfer* (June 15)	*300*, *Transformers*

Marvel Studios today: a small team working out of offices above a Mercedes-Benz dealership in Beverly Hills. It has just come through the 1990s bankruptcy era, is run by Avi Arad with Kevin Feige as president of production, and has bet $525 million of borrowed money and ten characters' film rights on itself. The rest of Hollywood thinks it's a toy company playing studio. San Diego Comic-Con (July 20-23) is where it will try to prove otherwise.

6. The Map of Power

Place	What happens there
Burbank	The Donohue lot **[OUR WORLD]** and Warner Bros. The industry's center of gravity.
Beverly Hills	Marvel Studios above the Mercedes dealership; agency offices; power lunches.
Bel Air	The Donohue estate **[OUR WORLD]**. Gated, quiet and absolute.
View Park / Baldwin Hills / Ladera Heights	The heart of Black L.A.'s professional class. The Smilley estate **[OUR WORLD]**.
Leimert Park	Black arts, jazz and spoken word. Where Simone Smilley goes when she wants to feel real **[OUR WORLD]**.
Century City, Culver City, Universal City, Melrose Ave.	Fox, Sony, Universal and Paramount, the other studio lots.
The Ivy, Mr. Chow, Chateau Marmont, Hyde Lounge	Paparazzi stakeouts, deal dinners and the nightlife of the celebutante era.
Roscoe's House of Chicken and Waffles	Where everyone in Black Hollywood, from both courts, pretends not to see each other.

7. The Road Ahead: Real 2006 Anchor Dates

Fixed real-world events the story will move through. **[OUR WORLD]** items are our alternate history.

Date	Event
May 1	“Day Without Immigrants” protests nationwide
May 5	Donohue closes the Pixar deal **[OUR WORLD]**; *Mission: Impossible III* opens
May 15-18	TV upfronts in New York: several of our actors' pilots live or die **[OUR WORLD]**
May 19 / May 26	*The Da Vinci Code*; *X-Men: The Last Stand*
June 9	Pixar's *Cars* (released through Donohue's Buena Vista **[OUR WORLD]**)
June 27 / June 28	BET Awards; *Superman Returns*
July 7	*Pirates of the Caribbean: Dead Man's Chest* (Donohue **[OUR WORLD]**) sets an opening-weekend record
July 15	Twitter launches
July 20-23	San Diego Comic-Con
September	**The *Iron Man* casting decision**: in real life, Robert Downey Jr. was announced September 29 **[OUR WORLD]**
Sept 26	Facebook opens to everyone
Nov 7	Midterm elections: Democrats take Congress
Nov 17	Marc-Anthony's *Starling* **[OUR WORLD]** opens against *Happy Feet* and *Casino Royale*. The PlayStation 3 launches (and the Wii on November 19).
Dec 15-25	*The Pursuit of Happyness*, *Dreamgirls* and *Night at the Museum*